



FOR B2B TECH EXHIBITORS

The Trade Show Playbook

HOW THREE DAYS TURN INTO A QUARTER
OF PIPELINE

Aspire Agency

A FREE GUIDE BY

Aspire

Most of a show is decided when nobody is there.

You have done this before. The stand looked right, the team was busy for three days and the scanner filled up. Six weeks later, the pipeline review showed a handful of real opportunities and a spreadsheet of names nobody wanted to call.

That gap is rarely a floor problem. It opens in two windows, one either side of the show.

Before the doors open. The people worth meeting book their three days before they land. If your meeting is not in their calendar by the week before, you are competing with every other stand for the ten minutes they have between appointments.

After the doors close. A buyer who has spoken to a dozen exhibitors in three days replies to the ones who wrote first and remembered what was said. Everyone else blurs into one.

The three days in between still matter. But mostly they execute what was agreed beforehand and produce the raw material for what happens afterwards.

This guide follows the real sequence: six weeks out, the week before, show week and the week after. Every section ends with something to do. The two tools at the back, a countdown checklist and a follow-up template, are the pages to print.

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Integrated Systems Europe, Barcelona. Three years working one of the largest audio visual conferences in the world, running the show floors and the social support for the organiser: 5,000+ new followers during the event, three years in a row.

SilTest Semiconductors. Attending as their external sales agency: generating qualified leads before the show, booking and taking the meetings, and handing them over qualified afterwards.

RatTech. A week of meetings in Dubai: a 90% follow-up rate, 30% of meetings converted to qualified opportunities, five pilots agreed.

Interactive Digital Media. On-site marketing and stand set-up, then the follow-up for their sales team after the show: around 75 meetings set, 35% converted.

DO THIS

Count back six weeks from your show's opening day and put that date in the calendar. That is your real start date.

01

PART 01 · SIX WEEKS OUT

Fill the diary.

Count one number before you travel: qualified meetings in the calendar. Everything in this part exists to raise it.

Build the list against who is actually attending

Your ideal customer profile tells you who you want. It does not tell you who will be in the hall. Start from evidence of attendance, then check for fit.

The exhibitor list.	Published by the organiser well ahead. Exhibitors are there for every day of the show, which makes them the easiest people to meet, as buyers, partners or channels.
The speaker programme.	Named people, confirmed in the building, with a session you can refer to.
The organiser's meeting platform or app.	If there is one, it is the only place you see who registered to visit, not just who paid to exhibit.
LinkedIn.	Search the event page and the show hashtag for people posting that they will be there. Check it every week from six weeks out.
Your own CRM.	Open opportunities, stalled conversations and customers in the region. Ask them directly whether they are going.
Partners and distributors.	Who is on their stand, and who are they bringing?

Tier the list

A

Tier A. Accounts where one meeting could move a live or likely deal. A named person, a personal message, a specific reason to meet. Keep it short enough that someone senior writes every message.

B

Tier B. The right profile, no relationship yet. A sequenced outreach, personalised to the company.

C

Tier C. Everyone else in your market who is attending. They get your pre-show posts and an open invitation to the stand. Nothing more.

DO THIS

Build the list in one sheet with five columns: company, contact, role, evidence they are attending, tier. No evidence, no Tier A.

The outreach sequence.

Four touches over four weeks. Each one adds something new, and each one makes yes easier to say.

TOUCH 1
SIX WEEKS OUT
EMAIL

Subject: [Show]: 20 minutes on [their problem, in five words]

Hi [Name],

I saw [Company] is [exhibiting at / speaking at / attending] [Show]. We're on stand [number].

[One sentence on the problem you solve for companies like theirs. Use a result if you have one.]

Would 20 minutes on [day] or [day] work? I'll hold a slot for you until [date].

[Your name]

Under 90 words. One reason, specific to them. Two days to choose from, never "let me know what suits". A date the slot is held until.

TOUCH 2
FIVE WEEKS OUT
LINKEDIN

A connection request with no pitch:

Connecting ahead of [Show]. I sent you a note about [topic], happy to pick it up here if that's easier.

TOUCH 3
FOUR WEEKS OUT
EMAIL, SAME
THREAD

Adding one thing: [colleague], who leads [area], will be on the stand on [day] and can walk you through [something specific to them]. Still holding [day] for you.

TOUCH 4
TWO WEEKS OUT
EMAIL, SAME
THREAD

The diary for [Show] closes on Friday. If the show doesn't work, a call the week after is just as useful. Which suits?

This turns a no to the show into a meeting after it.

Once a meeting is confirmed, send a calendar invite with the hall, the stand number and the mobile number of whoever is taking it. Confirm again 48 hours before.

DO THIS

Set a diary target for each person on the stand. If the floor is open eight hours, 30-minute meetings with 15 minutes between them give ten slots a day. Book six or seven, and leave the rest for overruns, walk-ups and lunch.

Why walk-up traffic is the least valuable thing a stand produces

Walk-ups choose you out of curiosity, not need. You know nothing about them before they arrive. They turn up when your team is busiest, between sessions and during booked meetings. And the conversation is usually over before anyone asks a qualifying question.

Treat walk-ups as a bonus to qualify quickly, never as the plan. One rule: nobody leaves a booked meeting to greet a walk-up.

WORTH ADDING

Something worth swapping a card for.

Merch people actually keep, a two-minute quiz that scores their setup, a prize draw for something your buyers would use. Make the card the price of entry. Then filter for quality: build one qualifying question into the swap ("What are you trying to fix this year?") and design the prize for your buyers, not for everyone in the hall. A good giveaway sorts the right people in, not just more people.

Agree the plan before anyone travels.

On the floor, every decision should be about execution, not direction. If someone is asking what to say about the new product at 10.15 on day one, the plan was never agreed.

Sign off these nine things, each with one name against it.

- 1 **The diary.** Every meeting has an owner, a backup and a one-line brief: who they are, what we want from the meeting, what happened last time.

OWNER _____

- 2 **The one message.** A single sentence everyone on the stand says when asked what you do and why it matters now. Written down, identical in every mouth.

OWNER _____

- 3 **The qualification questions.** The four questions every conversation must answer, agreed with sales. They are on page 7.

OWNER _____

- 4 **The capture method.** One tool, one format, tested on every phone. Badge scanner, CRM app or form: pick one, not three.

OWNER _____

- 5 **The content plan.** What gets published each day, by whom and where. Caption formats approved now, so nothing waits for sign-off on the floor.

OWNER _____

- 6 **The stand activity.** What visitors do on the stand, tested end to end, with a fallback for when the connection drops.

OWNER _____

- 7 **The rota.** Who is on the stand, who is in meetings and who is on a break, hour by hour. A tired team qualifies badly.

OWNER _____

- 8 **The follow-up.** The 24-hour and day-three emails drafted now, and who sends each one. They are on page 11, and they are easiest to write before anyone is tired.

OWNER _____

- 9 **The things nobody owns.** Chargers, a printed meeting list, every team member's mobile number, the stand number in every invite.

OWNER _____

DO THIS

Put the nine items in one document and book a 45-minute call to walk through the diary day by day. Nobody travels until every line has a name.

Run the stand like a meeting room, not a shop window.

Taking meetings

Start on time, even if you start without them.

The next meeting will not wait.

Open with what you know about them, not your pitch.

"When we last spoke you were looking at [X]. Where did that land?"

End with a next step and a date, said out loud and agreed.

"I'll send the pilot outline on Thursday. Can we speak the Tuesday after?"

Write the record within ten minutes of the meeting ending.

Not at the hotel. By 7pm, the eleventh conversation of the day has merged with the other ten.

Qualify as you go

Every conversation, booked or walk-up, answers four questions.

- 1 **Problem.** What are they trying to fix, in their words?
- 2 **Timing.** Is there a project, a budget cycle or a deadline?
- 3 **Role.** Do they decide, influence or research? Who else is involved?
- 4 **Next step.** What was agreed, by whom and by when?

Then grade it.

- A A real problem, a timeframe, access to the decision and an agreed next step with a date.
- B The right fit and a real problem, but no timing or no access to the decision yet.
- C Not a fit, or nothing beyond a scan.

Only A and B count as qualified leads. C is a contact. Record all of it against the contact in your CRM or capture tool, never in a notebook.

As the external sales agency for SilTest Semiconductors, this was the job: take the meeting, qualify it, and hand it to sales qualified. What arrives after the show should be pipeline, not a list.

DO THIS

Print the four questions and the three grades on a card for everyone on the stand.

The people who matter are mostly not in the building.

Publish in the same hour you capture

The people who matter most are mostly not in the building. The buyer who could not travel. The colleague of the person you met. The decision-maker your contact reports to.

The show is the most interesting thing you will post this quarter, and it stays interesting for about two days.

One person owns content, and it is their only job that day.

Capture and publish within the hour. A photo of a live demo with a two-line caption today beats a polished recap video next Thursday.

Post the substance, not the stand. What did a customer ask? What did a panel get wrong? What did you show? "Great day at stand 4B" tells nobody anything.

Tag the people you met, with their permission. It puts you in front of their network.

Use the formats approved the week before, so nothing waits for sign-off.

Three years running social support for the ISE organiser, two formats travelled furthest every time: short videos of on-stand trivia, and giveaways.

Give visitors something to do, not something to watch

A looping video on a screen is wallpaper. The stand opposite has one too. Give people a task that takes two to five minutes and starts a conversation on its own.

A live demo they drive themselves, on their own use case.

A short diagnostic. Three questions, an answer on screen, which someone from your team then explains. It doubles as qualification.

A test or challenge with a result worth photographing.

The test: does the activity give your team a natural reason to ask a qualifying question? If not, it is entertainment.

DO THIS

Write down the stand activity and the first question your team asks when a visitor finishes it.

04

PART 04 • THE WEEK AFTER

Close the loop while they still remember you.

The window is shorter than anyone thinks

In most teams, follow-up starts once everyone is back at their desks and has cleared the inbox. That is day four or five. By then the buyer has received the same "great to meet you" from every exhibitor they spoke to, and can no longer tell them apart.

90%

FOLLOW-UP RATE

30%

OF MEETINGS TO QUALIFIED OPPORTUNITIES

5

PILOTS AGREED

RATTECH • ONE WEEK OF MEETINGS IN DUBAI

Results like that are not made in the meeting. They are made in what happens next.

Badge scans are not qualified leads

A scan proves someone stood near your stand long enough to be scanned. Hand sales a spreadsheet of scans labelled "qualified leads from the show" and two things happen: they call the wrong people first, and they stop trusting marketing's numbers. Split before you hand over.

A and B: a personal email from the person they met within 24 hours, and a second at day three. Every A goes to sales the same day with a named owner.

C and unannotated scans: one useful email in the first week, then nurture. Never reported as qualified leads.

What to send, when, and what to record

Within 24 hours: personal, specific, confirming the agreed next step.

Day three: one useful thing they did not ask for, in the same thread.

Against every conversation: three fields. What they said, what was agreed, the grade.

The full template is on page 11.

The handover

Within two working days, marketing and sales go through every A and B together. Each one leaves the meeting with an owner and a date.

DO THIS

Send each day's 24-hour emails that evening, from the show. Then block the first working morning after it in every calendar: no inbox, no expenses, until every A and B has had its email.

The countdown.

Six weeks out to two weeks after. Put a name in every owner cell before you start.

WHEN	TASK	OWNER	DONE
6 WEEKS OUT	Set targets: qualified meetings booked, qualified leads (A and B), qualified opportunities at day 30	_____	☐
	Get the exhibitor list, the speaker programme and access to the meeting platform	_____	☐
	Build the target list with evidence of attendance; tier it A, B, C	_____	☐
	Send touch 1 to Tier A and Tier B	_____	☐
5 WEEKS OUT	Send touch 2 on LinkedIn to Tier A; brief the stand activity	_____	☐
4 WEEKS OUT	Send touch 3 in thread; publish the first pre-show post; agree the qualification questions with sales	_____	☐
3 WEEKS OUT	Set up the capture tool with a grade field; approve the content formats	_____	☐
2 WEEKS OUT	Send touch 4; review the diary against target and reassign slots	_____	☐
	Send calendar invites with hall, stand and mobile number for every confirmed meeting	_____	☐
WEEK BEFORE	Hold the sign-off call on the nine items	_____	☐
	Write a one-line brief for every meeting; draft the 24-hour and day-three emails	_____	☐
	Test the capture tool and stand activity; send 48-hour confirmations	_____	☐
SHOW DAYS	Morning: 15-minute stand-up on today's meetings and yesterday's count	_____	☐
	Record every conversation within ten minutes; publish within the hour	_____	☐
	Evening: send 24-hour emails to the day's A and B; count meetings held and grades	_____	☐
DAY 1 AFTER	Send any remaining 24-hour emails	_____	☐
DAY 2 AFTER	Hand over every A and B to sales, each with an owner and a date	_____	☐
DAY 3 AFTER	Send day-three emails; publish a recap for the people who were not there	_____	☐
WEEK 1 AFTER	Move C contacts and unannotated scans into nurture	_____	☐
WEEK 2 AFTER	Report against the measures on page 11; debrief on three things to keep and three to change	_____	☐

The follow-up.

Two emails and three fields. Sent by the person they met, from their own inbox, not from a marketing platform.

WITHIN 24 HOURS • A AND B

Subject: [Their topic]:
following up from [Show]

Hi [Name],

Good to meet you on [day] at [Show]. You mentioned [their problem, in their words].

As agreed, [the next step: the outline is attached / here are two times for the call, [day, time] or [day, time]].

[One line on why this matters for them specifically.]

Does [date] still work?

[Your name]

Rules: one detail only they would recognise. No attachment they did not ask for. Under 100 words.

DAY THREE • SAME THREAD

Hi [Name],

One thing that may help with [their problem]: [a short insight, a relevant result, a one-page overview or a two-minute video from the stand].

[Confirm the next step, or propose one if none was agreed.]

[Your name]

Rules: give, do not chase. Keep it in the same thread so the context travels with it.

RECORD AGAINST EVERY CONVERSATION

- 1 **What they said.** The problem in their words, and their role.
- 2 **What we agreed.** The next step, its owner and its date. "Nothing" is an answer, and it makes the grade B or C.
- 3 **The grade.** A, B or C. Timing and access to the decision decide it. Only A and B are qualified leads.

Measure the pipeline, not the footfall.

Footfall, scans and impressions describe activity. Report them if you must, never as the result.

If you track one number, track cost per qualified opportunity: $\text{total show cost divided by qualified opportunities at day 90}$. It is the figure you can compare with every other channel you run.

MEASURE	WHEN	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Qualified meetings booked, against target	Before the show	Whether the six weeks worked
Meetings held	Show week	Whether confirmations worked
Qualified leads (A and B)	End of show	What the conversations were worth
Follow-up rate	Day 14	Share of A and B who replied or took the next step
Qualified opportunities	Day 30	Accepted by sales, in the CRM with a value
Pipeline value and cost per qualified opportunity	Day 90	The quarter of pipeline, and what it cost
Revenue closed	Two to three quarters	Whether the show paid

For reference, RatTech's week in Dubai: a 90% follow-up rate and 30% of meetings converted to qualified opportunities.

DO THIS

Set a target for each line six weeks out. Review at day 30 and again at day 90.

Planning your next show?

Book a free fifteen-minute call through our website.